

TEACHER LESSON PLAN

Making Something New

Grades 3–4 · Homeroom / General

THE 35 MINUTES

5 min	10 min	15 min	5 min
HOOK	TEACH	ACTIVITY	CLOSING

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will understand that the Harlem Renaissance was a deliberate creative movement — that artists, writers, and musicians made a conscious choice to create something new and powerful in response to injustice. They will connect this to the idea of creative voice: that what you make can change how the world sees you. They will explore at least one Harlem Renaissance creative form through hands-on activity.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **CCSS.ELA-LITERACY RI.3.3 / RI.4.3** — Describe the relationship between events, ideas, or concepts in a historical text; explain connections between events
- **CCSS.ELA-LITERACY W.3.3 / W.4.3** — Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences; use descriptive detail and sequence
- **NCSS Standards I & II** — Culture: understand art as cultural expression; Time & Continuity: historical causes and effects of the Great Migration
- **National Arts VA:Cr1.1 / MU:Re7** — Generate and conceptualize artistic ideas; analyze how music connects to personal and cultural identity

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Device to play 60 seconds of Duke Ellington (“Take the A Train”) or Billie Holiday (“Strange Fruit” — emotionally powerful, teacher preview recommended)
- Optional: printed or projected image of Aaron Douglas artwork (e.g. *Aspects of Negro Life*, 1934)
- Differentiated handouts (Green / Yellow / Red) — one per student; pencils and optional colored pencils

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

What does injustice sound like?

Play 60–90 seconds of “Take the A Train.” No introduction — just let it play.

“That piece of music was written in 1941 by a man named Billy Strayhorn, who had just moved to New York City from the South. Duke Ellington told him: take the A train — that’s the subway line to Harlem. And he did. And he wrote that. What do you think he felt when he arrived in Harlem for the first time?”

Take 3–4 responses. Then:

“Today we’re going to look at what happens when a whole community of people — all at the same time — decide to make something new and powerful. What happens when artists, musicians, and writers all gather in one place and say: we have something to say, and we’re going to say it beautifully.”

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 10 MINUTES

The Harlem Renaissance

"From around 1910, hundreds of thousands of Black families left the South — escaping laws designed to keep them poor and afraid. They moved to Chicago, Detroit, Philadelphia, and especially Harlem in New York City. And in Harlem, something happened that no one had quite planned: every building was full of talent. Your neighbor might be Langston Hughes writing poetry. Across the street, Louis Armstrong was rehearsing jazz. Down the road, Zora Neale Hurston was collecting folk stories. Aaron Douglas was painting murals in geometric shapes and bold silhouettes."

"They weren't just making art. They were making a statement: Black life is rich, complex, beautiful, and important. This movement — this burst of creativity — we call the Harlem Renaissance."

Show the Aaron Douglas image if available. Ask: *"What do you notice? What do the shapes and silhouettes tell you about the mood?"*

ACTIVITY · 15 MINUTES

Your creative voice

Distribute differentiated handouts. Students may self-select or be assigned.

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Students choose a creative form (music, painting, story, poem) and fill in a planning frame: What will I make? Who am I making it for? What do I want them to feel? Then they sketch or draft a small sample.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Students write a short poem or paragraph in the voice of a Harlem Renaissance artist — first person, present tense, set in 1925. They then explain what their imagined creation says about Black life at that time.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Students analyze how two different creative forms — one visual, one musical or literary — made the same kind of argument in different ways. They choose two real figures and compare their approach, then write a critical response.

Suggested pairings: Aaron Douglas + Langston Hughes / Duke Ellington + Zora Neale Hurston

Circulate and engage students with their choices. In the final 3 minutes, invite sharing — particularly Red level students doing comparative analysis.

CLOSING · 5 MINUTES

Art as argument

"In the 1920s, some people said that Black people were not capable of great art or deep thinking. The Harlem Renaissance was, in a way, a very long answer to that. Every painting, every jazz record, every poem said: look at what we made. Art can be an argument. It can be a protest. It can be a declaration of who you are. When you write a story, or draw something, or make music — what are you saying about yourself?"

DIFFERENTIATION & CATHOLIC CONTEXT

Green uses planning frames to reduce the blank-page problem. Yellow requires first-person perspective-taking and historical context. Red requires analysis and comparison across creative forms. Allow students to move between levels; Red extension works well as homework.

Catholic school connection: The Harlem Renaissance connects naturally to CST Principle 1 (Human Dignity). The movement's central claim — that every human life is rich with worth and beauty — is deeply consonant with the Church's teaching on the inherent dignity of every person.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more firsthand. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: Explore the full exhibition online.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance